

Scorching Pitches: How Extreme Heat Could Reshape the 2026 World Cup

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When photos of shirtless, sweat-drenched European soccer players sprawled on the training pitch went viral last week, they weren't just a meme—they were a warning. The 2026 World Cup, set to kick off across the U.S., Mexico, and Canada, could be the hottest in the tournament's nearly 100-year history. Climate experts from World Weather Attribution estimate that 26 of the 104 matches could hit a Wet Bulb Globe Temperature (**WBGT**) of at least 26°C—a measure that combines heat, humidity, wind, and solar radiation to gauge how well the body can cool itself. Five games might even exceed 28°C **WBGT**, a level where heat stress becomes severe. The **WBGT** matters because when humidity is high, sweat doesn't **evaporate** as quickly, making it harder for athletes to **regulate their core temperature**. This can lead to **dehydration**, cramps, and fatigue, says physical performance coach Raiyan Abbasi, who has worked with Premier League clubs. He notes that while elite players are trained to handle diverse conditions, the sheer intensity of a World Cup match—90 minutes of sprinting in direct sunlight—amplifies the risk. Seventeen of the high-risk matches will be played in air-conditioned stadiums like those in Dallas, Houston, and Atlanta, but nine others lack such cooling. That has teams scrambling to adapt. Norway's squad made headlines by wearing ice collars during a friendly against Morocco. England captain Harry Kane, however, brushed off concerns after his team's 1-0 win in Tampa, Florida, where temperatures soared past 30°C. "It won't be a factor," he said, crediting their training regimen. Abbasi agrees that **acclimatization** and preparation can level the playing field, and even suggests that heat training can boost athletic performance. Still, the tournament underscores a broader trend: climate change is making outdoor sports increasingly **precarious**. As Al Jazeera meteorologist Everton Fox puts it, "Around half a dozen of the venues are prone to extreme heat." For fans and players alike, the 2026 World Cup may be as much a test of endurance as skill.

Word Treasure

WBGT -- WBGT stands for Wet Bulb Globe Temperature, a measure that combines heat, humidity, wind, and sunshine to show how well the body can cool itself through sweat.

acclimatization -- Acclimatization means getting your body used to a new climate, like training in hot weather so you can perform safely when it's hot.

dehydration -- Dehydration happens when the body loses too much water, often through sweating, and can cause tiredness and dizziness.

evaporate -- To evaporate means a liquid (like sweat) turns into a gas. When humidity is high, sweat evaporates slowly, making it harder to cool down.

regulate their core temperature -- This means controlling the body's internal temperature so it doesn't get too hot or too cold, which is vital for organs to work properly.

precarious -- Something precarious is dangerous or unstable, like a situation that could easily become much worse.

Background you need

The World Cup has not always been played in searing summer heat. The 2022 tournament in Qatar was moved to November and December to avoid dangerous temperatures, and many stadiums there were fully air-conditioned. In 2026, the event returns to June and July in North America, where heatwaves are becoming more intense due to climate change. World Weather Attribution (an international group of climate scientists) says that such extreme heat events are now more likely and more severe. The WBGT index was developed by the U.S. military decades ago to protect soldiers from heat illness, and it's still used today by sports organizations to decide if it's safe to play. In some past World Cups, matches had mandatory water breaks when the heat became too risky, something we might see again.

Break it down

LEAD: Viral photos of sweat-drenched players are a warning about heat at the 2026 World Cup.

+ specific: Shirtless, exhausted European players sprawled on the training pitch.

STATISTICAL FORECAST: World Weather Attribution estimates 26 of 104 matches could exceed 26°C WBGT, with 5 matches over 28°C.

+ WHO: Climate experts and a physical performance coach (Raiyan Abbasi).

+ WHAT: WBGT explained -- a combination of temperature, humidity, wind, and solar radiation.

+ WHY: Sweat doesn't evaporate in high humidity, causing dehydration, cramps, and fatigue.

VENUES AND ADAPTATION: 17 high-risk matches will be in air-conditioned stadiums, but 9 others lack cooling.

+ EXAMPLE: Norway used ice collars; Harry Kane dismissed concerns.

+ COACH'S VIEW: Acclimatization can level the playing field and even boost performance.

CLIMATE CONTEXT: A meteorologist notes that around half a dozen venues are prone to extreme heat, underscoring how climate change makes outdoor sports more precarious.

OPEN QUESTION: Will endurance and adaptation prove as important as skill at this World Cup?

Why it matters

As the planet warms, outdoor activities you love -- from school sports to major tournaments -- face new risks, and the way organizers adapt could influence everything from when games are played to how athletes prepare in the future.

Test what you remember

1. What does WBGT measure?

- ☐ (A) The chance of rain during a match
- ☐ (B) How well the body can cool itself
- ☐ (C) The distance players run in a game
- ☐ (D) The strength of the wind on the pitch

2. Why is a high WBGT dangerous for soccer players?

- ☐ (A) It makes the grass too slippery
- ☐ (B) It reduces the number of fans in the stadium
- ☐ (C) Sweat doesn't evaporate quickly, so the body overheats
- ☐ (D) The ball becomes harder to kick accurately

3. How many of the 2026 World Cup matches might reach a WBGT of at least 26°C?

- ☐ (A) 5
- ☐ (B) 17
- ☐ (C) 26
- ☐ (D) 104

4. Which team used ice collars during a friendly match?

- ☐ (A) England
- ☐ (B) Morocco
- ☐ (C) Norway
- ☐ (D) Canada

5. What was Harry Kane's attitude toward the heat risks?

- ☐ (A) He was extremely worried and asked for a schedule change
- ☐ (B) He thought it wouldn't be a factor and credited training
- ☐ (C) He blamed the organizers for not providing air conditioning
- ☐ (D) He said the heat made the match unfair for his team

6. Which of these is NOT mentioned as a way to cope with extreme heat?

- ☐ (A) Playing in air-conditioned stadiums
- ☐ (B) Acclimatization and heat training
- ☐ (C) Postponing all matches until the evening
- ☐ (D) Wearing ice collars

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: C 4: C 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

- 1. Positive / optimistic:** Coaches like Raiyan Abbasi believe that proper heat training and acclimatization can not only protect players but also give them a competitive edge, making the matches a true test of athleticism and preparation.
- 2. Negative / critical:** Critics worry that the heat could lead to health emergencies on the pitch, and that teams from cooler climates are unfairly disadvantaged. Unequal access to air-conditioned stadiums might also tilt the playing field.
- 3. Neutral / analytical:** Heat stress in sports is not new, but the increasing frequency of extreme weather events reveals a pattern: major sporting bodies must now routinely integrate climate adaptation into their planning, just as they already handle security and logistics.
- 4. Forward-looking:** The 2026 World Cup could push FIFA to adopt permanent heat policies, such as mandatory water breaks, heat guidelines for match scheduling, or even reconsidering summer tournaments altogether in a warming world.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):